
First Trip

A small, complete plan

ChatGPT edition

Before leaving

1. Confirm legal access, weather, exact-water 2026–27 rules, consumption advice and posted boating ordinances. Leave a float plan.
2. Pack fitted PFDs, water, sun/weather layers, charged waterproofed phone, first aid, pliers, cutters, knotless rubber net and AIS-cleaning supplies.
3. Rig one slip bobber and one simple jig or split-shot setup; carry a spare. Use legal bait from a lawful source.

A two-hour search

First 15 min	Observe wind, clarity, temperature, vegetation, traffic and bait.
Next 45 min	Fish one shallow edge. Change depth before changing everything.
Next 45 min	Test one break or saddle. Record bottom and contact depth.
Last 15 min	Photograph notes, clean/drain/remove, secure hooks and leave on time.

Beginner rule

One safe, repeatable presentation fished attentively teaches more than a box of constant changes. A bite is evidence; no bite is also evidence. Move only after you can state what depth, cover and speed you actually tested.

STOP CONDITIONS

Return early for thunder, rising wind, poor visibility, equipment trouble, cold stress, unsafe traffic or uncertainty about access or law. A small open boat is not lightning shelter. Wear the PFD.

Source basis: Wisconsin DNR Hook, Line & Thinker; boating safety; PFD; AIS and bait law; 2026–27 regulations; NOAA/NWS inland boating.

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